# Michael Sweet - 60 Minute Meeting-20260513_125647-Meeting Recording

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1h 8m 8s

**Rick Snide** started transcription

**Rick Snide** 0:16
Dear Michael.

**Michael Sweet** 0:17
Hey, Rick, how are you?

**Rick Snide** 0:19
I'm good, how are you?

**Michael Sweet** 0:20
Pretty good.

**Rick Snide** 0:21
I don't see your, I don't see you. Is your camera on?

**Michael Sweet** 0:25
Yeah.
It is, hold on a second.
Technology.

**Rick Snide** 0:33
Yeah.
There you are.

**Michael Sweet** 0:38
There we go. Beautiful.

**Rick Snide** 0:40

Perfect. Perfect. Hey, if you don't mind, I'm going to record this so I can, I don't have to take notes mostly for that for the transcription.

**Michael Sweet** 0:46
Sure.
Absolutely.

**Rick Snide** 0:50
How have you been? You know, I remember when Ken sent me your name, I said, I remember Michael Sweet. That name's familiar. And I thought I even remembered what you looked like. And
And I, so when I saw your, and you kind of had a little icon of your picture or whatever in something, LinkedIn or something like that, that it was connected to me. I was like, that, yeah, I do remember. I do remember, Michael.

**Michael Sweet** 1:19
Yeah.
But.
I think we actually, I think I interviewed with you guys.

**Rick Snide** 1:28
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 1:29
Gosh, I was trying to think when, like 20.
Thirteen, 14.

**Rick Snide** 1:33
I think, I think it was in that, I think it was in that neighborhood.

**Michael Sweet** 1:36
Yeah.

**Rick Snide** 1:38
I think, yeah, I think it was. So what have you been up to the last few years anyway? I

mean, guess why don't we just start it like this? Why don't you just like super high level? I mean, I breezed through your resume and I know, you know, a little bit about where you've been, but maybe if you can just tell me like in
like 3 minutes, you know, the highlights of the moves you made over the over your career now.

MS **Michael Sweet** 2:05
Sure, okay. Well, as you know, I was, I started pretty much at Cornell many years ago. Got my kind of feet wet.

**Rick Snide** 2:11
Mhm.
And you knew, did you know Jeremy Gentry from there, or was it Keith Cord?

MS **Michael Sweet** 2:18
Yep. No, actually, Jeremy and I worked together. He was my service. I was on the hardware side. He was on the service side. So we had the...

**Rick Snide** 2:25
I was thinking it was Jeremy, yeah.

MS **Michael Sweet** 2:27
Yeah, yeah, because I know he worked there for a few years, right? With you guys? And uh...

**Rick Snide** 2:30
Oh yeah, he did. Yeah. Yeah. Several years.

MS **Michael Sweet** 2:32
Yep, and then then Veronica Ahmed worked for you guys briefly.

**Rick Snide** 2:36
Right.
Yeah, yeah, she was really a short timer. She was in the account management role and...

MS **Michael Sweet** 2:43

Oh, gotcha.

**Rick Snide** 2:44

I, I don't recall why it was, but why it was she wanted to go, but she wanted to go, she wanted to go, so...

MS **Michael Sweet** 2:50

Yep. Yes, so did Cornell for about 11 years and really great start into sales. You know, it was one of those things where, you know, distribution is such a different animal than direct selling. So it was good to kind of understand that. Moved on to Visioneer, so their hardware manufacturer.

**Rick Snide** 3:06

Yeah.

MS **Michael Sweet** 3:10

That was really a good opportunity for me. I'd worked with Rusty James, was the Fujitsu Vice President of Sales, and worked with him when I was at Cornell. And so he said, hey, you know, come on. So I worked there for a couple of years. And then New Wave came calling. And so I went to another distributor.

**Rick Snide** 3:18

Mhm.

MS **Michael Sweet** 3:29

And then I moved on to software sales, worked for DocStar. And you know, the good news is through my career, Rick, I've kind of done a little bit of everything. I've worked for resellers. I've worked for distribution. So I understand the channel. A lot of great contacts over the years, a lot of different territories. You know, I've had

**Rick Snide** 3:39

Mhm.

Mhm.
Right, right.

**Michael Sweet** 3:50
Ohio for probably the last, well, probably 10 or 12 years. Kind of fast forward, I worked at Fireproof Records down in Grove City. And they were actually, we were acquired by Vital Records Control in 2020, right at the time of COVID. So literally, Mike James sold the company.

**Rick Snide** 3:54
Mhm.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 4:09
And then three weeks later, COVID hit. So yeah, great, great timing for him. He got out at the perfect time. And so did work for VRC and then jumped over to BPS. That was my last last job I had and worked for them for about a year and was really on board with them just to under they wanted to grow their digital

**Rick Snide** 4:12
Good timing, huh?
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 4:32
software solutions. You know, I don't know if you're familiar with them. They used to be HMB.

**Rick Snide** 4:37
Yeah, yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 4:38
Uh, yep, so they, and they sold their...

**Rick Snide** 4:40
Tom, Tom Harris, you mean, right? Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 4:42
Yep, Tom Harris. The guy there now is John Pater, and he was the guy that was kind of running the scanner software side of the business. And so I think in 2020, they sold their business, the managed services piece over to CTI. And they just, you know, they just kind of get together again. And so it's with Mark Beaky, John Pater, and then John Sonner.

**Rick Snide** 4:45
Mm-hmm.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 5:03
and they just created BPS. So they brought me on to, you know, kind of grow their digital, you know, software sales. Also could sell their managed services products. They did more of staffing was kind of their big thing. You know, they really wanted to, you know, get people into staffing, you know, into businesses. And so they've been pretty successful doing that. So

**Rick Snide** 5:05
Okay.
Mhm.
What was the digital sales part of it?

**Michael Sweet** 5:28
So we brought on Digitech and Filebound, so two document management software solutions. When I was at Fireproof, we sold those, so I had a lot of contacts there. And he really, he had a great...

**Rick Snide** 5:35
Okay.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 5:44
Great product, as far as you know, sold so many scanners over the years, it was crazy,

and he really wanted to kind of go and say, "Hey, you know, it's great to sell a scanner, but what are you guys doing when you know the other side of it?" So, his, you know, my job is really to kind of go out there, get the world to know that we're selling digital, you know, software solutions now, go back to some of the existing customers.

**Rick Snide** 5:55
Mhm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 6:04
try to see if there was a fit there. And then on the main services side, I actually sold a deal for Red Roof Inn. It's been one of my customers forever. Back when I was at Fireproof, we sold Esker, was one of our accounts payable software solutions, sold it to them. So I've known them for probably 10 years.

**Rick Snide** 6:06
Mhm.
Mhm.
Yeah.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 6:23
And they're an Oracle shop and their Oracle person actually passed away. So they were using some, you know, third party company to kind of manage the Oracle services piece. So when I was at BPS, we had a partner down in Texas, got that relationship going. So that was about, you know, 8 grand a month for

**Rick Snide** 6:24
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 6:44
You know, for services, so it's a nice little opportunity, and there's a lot more there, you know, it's just that was just one of the...

**Rick Snide** 6:44
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 6:51
successes I had when I was there at BPS.

**Rick Snide** 6:53
Was that in terms of being managed, what kind of services were provided for that?

**Michael Sweet** 7:01
So basically with the Red Roof, because they didn't really have a person to manage the Oracle piece, our partner down in Texas, they're an Oracle shop basically. So they were going to do all the, take the first calls, do all the updates, and kind of manage the Oracle piece of the business.

**Rick Snide** 7:08
Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 7:20
So it was, yeah, it was, it was a great, you know, great opportunity for us because really we partnered with them. We just, you know, we got 1000 bucks a month for really doing the introduction, which is, you know, kind of a nice thing, you know, but yeah, so there's, yeah, that was a, that was a nice one. And that's kind of it, you know, from

**Rick Snide** 7:21
Gotcha, gotcha.
Mhm, mhm.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 7:40
Granalda now and just looking to keep the sales rolling.

**Rick Snide** 7:42

Mhm.

Right.

Right, right. Did you, I know that, you know, that business or those businesses are, you know, fairly different from what we're doing. But what's your process been for, you know, prospecting and, you know, getting new leads and all? Has that mostly been driven from marketing to bringing in new leads or how's that been working for you?

**Michael Sweet** 8:10

No, really, I'd probably say 60 to 70% is just me out there. You know, I'm on LinkedIn all the time, you know, because at Fireproof,

**Rick Snide** 8:18

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 8:21

We have like 1500 customers just in the central Ohio area. So there's a lot of contacts there. You know, the good news is we don't really, you know, there's no competition at all because they do, you know, box storage, shredding, things of that nature. So I have a nice little, you know, database of folks that I've, you know, tried to keep in contact with.

**Rick Snide** 8:25

Mhm.

Mhm.

Mhm.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 8:41

You know how it is in sales, you know, even though I'm not still at a place, I still periodically reach out and say, hey, how you doing? You know, how are things going over there? Yeah, exactly. So LinkedIn is really, you know, a big thing for me too. Chamber of Commerce, I was really, when I was at Fireproof, I was, they had an ambassador program.

**Rick Snide** 8:42
Mmh.
Yeah, for sure.
I've got something else.

**Michael Sweet** 9:01
I don't know if you're familiar with that at all, but...

**Rick Snide** 9:03
Mmh.

**Michael Sweet** 9:04
They reached out to me and I said, yeah, absolutely, I'll do it. So basically what would happen is I would just go to the events and, you know, every time you go to an event, there's always people kind of just standing there by themselves, not really networking. So the ambassador's job was really to go over and just start talking to them, let them know about, you know, the chamber. Oh, by the way, you know.

**Rick Snide** 9:17
Right.
Yeah.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 9:24
I'm also at Fireproof, you know, things like that. So those are things, I try to just go to like a lot of networking events. I'm not in any of those, you know, kind of groups that, you know, meet weekly or whatever, but I go to, there's some events that like Cohatch and things like that, just trying to, you know, again, just get your name out.

**Rick Snide** 9:26
Yeah, right, right.
Mm-hmm.
Right, right.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 9:43

And this is what I do. I've gone to a few of the breakfasts, first breakfasts they have every month. Those are okay, but I've noticed over the years, you kind of get a lot of sales guys going to talk to sales guys. You know, it's kind of like, well, this isn't really open.

**Rick Snide** 9:45

Mm-hmm.

Right, right, yeah.

Yeah, right.

Right.

Right. We used to sponsor those, you know, maybe once a year or whatever, and we kind of got to that same conclusion that everybody's a salesperson that's here, right? Can't talk to anybody. I mean, there's some good in that, but you know, you know, not the decision makers.

**Michael Sweet** 10:01

Yeah.

Okay.

Yeah, yeah, where's Elliott?

Right.

Yeah, it's, yeah, and also associations. One of the things I was doing at BPS was, you know, talk to them about trying to figure out ways to obviously get the brand name out for BPS. And what better way to do it is to just, you know, kind of talk to associations, see if there's things you can do like member benefits, you know, say, hey, guess what? We're an MSP.

**Rick Snide** 10:28

Mhm.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 10:39

Here's what we can provide for your members. Either we'll give them a discount, we'll give you a kickback, you know, something to kind of, you know, make it a win-win for both. And my wife works at the Columbus Bar Association. So I have access to like 5,000, you know, attorneys.

**Rick Snide** 10:41
Mhm.
Mm.
Mhm.
Mhm.
Yeah.
I was just there yesterday and we had a meeting there.

**Michael Sweet** 10:57
Oh, you were?
Oh, nice. Okay.

**Rick Snide** 11:00
Yeah, nice offices.

**Michael Sweet** 11:03
Yeah, yep, yeah, they just moved. They used to be down on 3rd, but now they're over at, you know, Arena District. And yeah, so it's, but with that, it's the same type of thing. You know, they have 5,000 members, a lot are solo, you know, practitioners or maybe four or five people in an office. Those are perfect candidates for, you know, your products.

**Rick Snide** 11:03
Heather.
Right, right.
Mm-hmm.
Mm-mm.

**Michael Sweet** 11:23
You know, especially main services, because people just don't have the, you know, they'll say, yeah, my brother-in-law kind of knows IT. Well, that's not a solution.

**Rick Snide** 11:26
Mm-hmm.
Mhm, right. Right.

**Michael Sweet** 11:35
That's a recipe for disaster is what that is, but...

**Rick Snide** 11:38
Right. So I think you probably know what we do in hearing about us and being around us for a bit, but just to give you a little bit of, you know, a little bit of level up on where we are now, I suppose. The, we actually just,

**Michael Sweet** 11:53
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 11:59
Just a week, well, on May 1st, so almost, I guess, just almost two weeks ago, we sold the ERP division. So we used to have a Salesforce consulting division. We had an ERP consulting division, so primarily selling the...

**Michael Sweet** 12:06
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 12:17
manufacturing software called Plex, which is owned by Rockwell Automation now. We sold that, the ERP division, on May 1st. So we are consolidated and focused now on just our managed service business.

**Michael Sweet** 12:22
Okay.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 12:36
which is really, it's really a breath of fresh air for us because we, especially

manufacturing has been such a struggle over the past few years. You know, so we're really excited about the, you know, the ability to focus here. But that

**Michael Sweet** 12:36
Okay.
Sure, yeah.

**Rick Snide** 12:56
That's one piece, but so our customers are, we typically, we'd have two really two basic lines of business. One is a fully managed.
IT service business, and one of them is a co-managed IT service business. So it doesn't really matter the size, but basically, I mean, in terms of how large it is, but the...

**Michael Sweet** 13:17
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 13:28
customers that we like are, let's say, 20 to 100 employees fully managed. And although we have some that are fully managed that are a couple 100, but typically once you get over 100 or 150, 200,

**Michael Sweet** 13:39
OK.

**Rick Snide** 13:50
it makes more sense to have at least some IT staff. And that's where we step into that co-managed model, where what we like to do in that model is we take care of all of the back end, so all the cloud servers and all the security and all of that.

**Michael Sweet** 13:54
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 14:09
and the customer that's co-managed has a help desk, and they do the first level

support, and then they escalate to us if they get stuck. That's our preferred co-managed methodology. Most of our customers are fully managed, so we do everything from help desk through strategy, security, everything.

**Michael Sweet** 14:17
Okay.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 14:31
So, that's what we do, and we do a lot of add-on projects related to that. We do a lot of Microsoft licensing and other licensing. We can do a la carte of some of that, like... We can just sell our security product, which is not ours, the one that we sell. We can license that to, you know, somebody that just needs that, right? And we're just reselling that.

**Michael Sweet** 15:10
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 15:11
We've got a couple of things like that that we can do around security, you know, where we, they, you know, in that case, they're getting the full security operations center model behind the scenes that's, you know, alerting us when they have a, you know, when they allow their, you know...
credentials to get compromised or whatever, right? And the security training and all of those pieces, right? We can resell all that stuff and we provide that, we basically provide all that stuff as a part of our managed service, but we can do it a la carte as well. So that's

**Michael Sweet** 15:33
Sure.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 15:49
kind of where we are right now. We've got about 30 people. We were at 100 back

when we had the ERP and the Salesforce division. So we've shed our offices that we had if you were at those offices.

**Michael Sweet** 15:52
Okay.
Oh wow, okay.

**Rick Snide** 16:10
And we've got some offices at a co-working facility right now, which we've had for several years now. We pretty much got out of a pretty large office space right after COVID started. So, and people just didn't want to come back.

**Michael Sweet** 16:25
Okay, yeah.

**Rick Snide** 16:29
to an office space. So we just have a little bit of office space now.
So anyway, that's what we do. You know, we, I guess I'd be interested in hearing, you know, when you talk about.

**Michael Sweet** 16:37
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 16:44
you know, where you were at BPS and managed services there. Did you be able to do sell some other kinds of managed services or was it really just around like you were saying that managed Oracle service and that kind of thing like that?

**Michael Sweet** 17:02
Yeah, they had, well, they had staffing was one of their big things too. You know, they would go in and say, hey, you know, if you guys don't have, or if you need like a code, a coder for, you know, Java for six months, we can provide that, that person for you. That was one of the things they did. I never did any of that. That was kind of, they had a couple other folks that were doing that.

**Rick Snide** 17:16

Mm-hmm.

Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 17:22

And on the managed services side, you know, like I said, we really, I tried to, you know, bundle in the, because I did the digital, but then I'd start talking to folks and they'd be like, yeah, we, you know, we've been having some issues with micro man. So do you know anybody? And be like, well, yeah, absolutely. I happen to know somebody, you know, it's.

**Rick Snide** 17:36

Mhm.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 17:41

And we did a similar to, you know, methodology that you guys have. We could do all of it or just part of it, you know, really kind of, you know, leaving it to the customer as to kind of what they really need. You know, after we get in there and start, you know, talking to them, yeah, we have no security systems or we need help with that. Okay, we can provide that for you or we can, you know,

**Rick Snide** 17:48

Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 18:01

give you some products that would help you with that. So we kind of did a little bit of everything, if that makes sense. And again, we were working with the Columbus Bar Association because their IT person left and they're using Microman. They weren't really happy with them. I don't know why. I don't know if they weren't very responsive or.

**Rick Snide** 18:04

Mhm.

Mhm.

Mm.

**Michael Sweet** 18:22

I don't really know much about them, but you know, those are the types of agencies that, again, I was, you know, trying to target because they're gold mines. And really, the associations, if you can get...

**Rick Snide** 18:22

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 18:35

Into those, I had I had a lot of calls in the folks and there was some stuff, you know, some people are like, well, it's $1000, you know, for $1000 you can sponsor and I'm like...

**Rick Snide** 18:36

Mhm.

Yeah, right.

**Michael Sweet** 18:46

There's no guarantee. You know, I mean, it's nice. You know, it would get you in front of, say, 500 people, but now I'm going, I'm spending 1000, so it's 20 bucks a head. You know, hopefully out of those, you know, 500 people.

**Rick Snide** 18:49

Yeah.

Mhm.

Mhm.

Mhm, right.

**Michael Sweet** 18:59

somebody's going to say, hey, you know, that sounds good. So I tried to find the association to be like, yeah, let's, you know, we'll just put it up there and, you know, kind of if it's, if it works, it does. If it doesn't, it doesn't. So, you know, yeah, the.

**Rick Snide** 19:02

Right.

Mhm.

Yeah.

Yeah, if they can, if they can, I think you said before, if they can offer a discount to their members or something along those lines, then that's a win for them.

**Michael Sweet** 19:20

Mhm.

Yeah.

Yeah, absolutely. And, you know, in this day and age, I think a lot of these associations are having trouble trying to get members, keep members. So, you know, we would look at, hey, what if, you know, we'll give you 10%, you know, or something. So that way they're getting something. So now they're just getting in the game for them if they allow us to partner with them. So

**Rick Snide** 19:29

Mhm, mhm.

Mhm.

Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 19:44

I'm always just trying to figure out strategic ways, because you know how it is in sales. You know, sometimes it's easier to get in with one person and let them sell for you as opposed to you trying to knock on everybody's door. When I was at Visioneer, I had the responsibility for CDW. And my gosh, you would go in there and

**Rick Snide** 19:55

Mm.

Mm.

Yeah, yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 20:09

And so the only way to really get any traction would they'd have like vendor days and you just have a little, you know, a little table set up and they'd come over and they'd go, what's Visioneer? And you talk to them and, hey, we're on a special. If you guys sell this particular product, you get 10 bucks and they get all excited, you know, but to do it as just a call in and try to do that with, you know, 500 guys would take forever. You never.

**Rick Snide** 20:12

Mhm.

Right.

Mmh.

Yeah.

Right.

**Michael Sweet** 20:29

You know, you don't get, you're just one of how many other people, so...

**Rick Snide** 20:32

Right, right, right. So when you were at BPS then, did you have a pipeline of these kinds of customers that I'm talking about, like the small, medium, you know, kind of customers or, you know, what kind of pipeline?

Would you say that you had?

**Michael Sweet** 20:54

I would say they had similar, I mean, they had some big accounts, like they had Huntington and a few of those large ones. But, you know, truth be told, I mean, most people are doing the same thing that you guys are doing. You know, it's more of the small to medium businesses because that's really the only, it's so hard to get into Huntington. You got to go through, you know,

**Rick Snide** 20:58

Mhm.

Mhm.

Mhm.

Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 21:13
layers and years of people as opposed to going to, you know, some small operation that has 20 people or 50 people, you know.

**Rick Snide** 21:16
Mhm.
You know, it's like, I think 75% or something like that of all companies are like 10 people or less or something like that. So yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 21:25
Yeah.
Yeah.
Well, and you think about that, you know, if you have 10 people or less, guaranteed you don't have an IT person. I mean, you can't afford, you can't afford some guy that's gonna be, you gotta pay him 90 or 100 grand. You know, it's better off to, you know, have a service like ours where we say, okay, we're gonna, you know, we'll charge you 3 or 400 bucks a month. I don't know what the pay is, but you know, something like that where,

**Rick Snide** 21:36
Yeah.
Right, right.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 21:50
We're going to be your IT staff. You know, we're going to manage your updates on Microsoft and you know, we're going to have your securities, make sure it's tight so somebody can't come in and hack your systems and you know, all that stuff. So yeah, I mean, really, most places I've worked at, especially like at Fireproof, most of our businesses.

**Rick Snide** 21:56
Mhm.

Right.
Right.

**Michael Sweet** 22:10
When I was there, were small to medium businesses easily. I mean, we had Ohio Health and the big ones, but you know, you take those out of the mix and those are the hardest ones to work with. You know, you know that is, the bigger they are, boy, they get the clout and they get the...

**Rick Snide** 22:13
Mhm, mhm.
Mhm.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 22:29
You know, they demand a lot. And yeah, I mean, the smaller ones can be a challenge because they might call you more often because they're not understanding something. But I don't know. I'd rather have 50 small companies than one large, because if large has a problem and goes, you're out of business. If you got 50, you lose 5, you still got 45. So you still got your

**Rick Snide** 22:29
Yeah, yeah, they're demanding.
Yeah.
Right, right.

**Michael Sweet** 22:50
You're still making your money, so...

**Rick Snide** 22:50
Right.
Right, right. So just to clarify, your, I'm just trying to understand what kind, you know, how many opportunities, a managed service kind of opportunities would you?
You know, would you say you had it in your funnel when you were when you left, you

know, and and what do those look like? I'm just trying to get a sense of the volume of things that you're working on.

MS **Michael Sweet** 23:19
Sure. I probably had...
Maybe 10 to 15 main services, actual ones going on. Some were just in the initial, you know, maybe an introduction. I need to get was, you know, I need to talk to my person over here to see if, you know, we can get a meeting and stuff, you know, an additional meeting, things like that. So yeah, probably 10 to 15.

**Rick Snide** 23:25
Mhm.
Mhm.

MS **Michael Sweet** 23:43
And as far as dollar wise, maybe 40 or 50,000, you know, worth of potential business.

**Rick Snide** 23:52
For the whole, for the whole funnel.

MS **Michael Sweet** 23:53
Yep, yep. You know, again, being focused on the digital side, it was a little different. So, but like I said, almost everybody I talked to, there's still a need. You know, it's so.

**Rick Snide** 24:00
Mm-hmm.
Mhm, mhm.
Yeah, the.
I guess the one of the questions that I wanted to ask you was, when you were when when you're out there selling now, who are the who are the people that you normally sell to?
I I mean, as in role, you know.

MS **Michael Sweet** 24:29
Sure. Yep. Typically, it's, you know, if it's, if we're looking at MSP world, it's going to

be more the director. I always try to go like IT directors. Again, depending on the size of the business, you know, if it's a smaller business, I might be talking to, you know, you as the owner. But I would tip it, you know, like when I go to LinkedIn, I would just

**Rick Snide** 24:41
Mhm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 24:48
bring up ABC Company and kind of go through their list of folks they have and kind of see, you know, what's the best.
Best ave to go with, based on the size of the company, but...

**Rick Snide** 25:02
Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 25:03
And again, it really depends. Sometimes I might know somebody that knows somebody in there. So I'd be like, hey, can you, you know, based on what you know in this company, who should I, who should I target? You know, and that's really the key too, is if you know somebody somewhere, it's so much easier. You know, it's not just a blind email or, you know, voicemail that maybe they'll listen to.

**Rick Snide** 25:13
Mm-hmm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 25:23
Enough 3 weeks from now, or or what have you, so...

**Rick Snide** 25:25
Yeah, right, right, yeah.
Do you?
Do you?
Do you think?

Based on, you know, you've been out in the community quite a bit now, do you think there's a lot of...
opportunity to touch those those particular roles that you're talking about and you know to sell managed services to.

**Michael Sweet** 25:55
I think it's becoming more challenging just because of the whole AI climate and people are really...

**Rick Snide** 25:59
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 26:05
You know, unfortunately, they watch the news and say, hey, AI, it's going to change, it's going to solve all our problems in business. Well, you know, there's good parts about it, you know, don't get me wrong, but it's, I think we're still a year or two away from really making some huge inroads. I mean, some of the bigger organizations,

**Rick Snide** 26:10
Mm-hmm.
Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 26:24
you know, that have staff upon staff that can, you know, that has the expertise. But for most of the smaller businesses, I think they hear it. It sounds great. You know, you can do some cool things with it, but from a practical standpoint, we're still a ways away.

**Rick Snide** 26:25
Mm-hmm.
Mm-hmm.
Right.
Mhm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 26:43
And, as far as you know, reaching some of these folks.
My experience over the past probably six months or so, a lot of businesses, the good news is they're not getting rid of folks.

**Rick Snide** 26:55
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 26:56
But I think they're kind of doing Pat on, you know, do we hire additional IT staff or do we, you know.

**Rick Snide** 27:02
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 27:03
kind of keep what we have. That's been kind of things I've been seeing. You know, like I'll reach out to folks and they'll be like, well, we had a person and now, you know, that person is leaving or, you know, so.

**Rick Snide** 27:15
Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 27:16
I think it's, again, my target is always the IT folks, because that's obviously who we're selling to. But sometimes I just change and say, I'm just going to talk to the CEO and hand or, you know, resident of the company or whomever, because they might have a different viewpoint of where they want to see the business go. Because if you go talk to an IT person,

**Rick Snide** 27:23
Hey.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 27:39
immediately, they're going to think, well, they're going to come at, I'm going to talk myself out of a job. You know what I mean? So you kind of get that. They're going to be like, yeah, we're fine. We don't need any help. Well, they might, you know. So, you know, I kind of just, it really goes back and forth with me sometimes. I'm like, let's try the IT person. OK, well, if I don't have success with that person,

**Rick Snide** 27:45
Yeah.
Right.
Right.

**Michael Sweet** 27:59
I'll go, you know, another another direction. I mean, I've gone to HR people and just talk to them, because, you know, sometimes or accounting, they they a lot of times those people give you a lot of good information, you know, like our system's terrible, you know, we can't do this, we can't do that, or you know, what have you, so...

**Rick Snide** 27:59
Mhm.
Mm-hmm.
Mhm.
Mhm.
Right, right. Yeah. Yeah, I would say our typical customer, which is, like I said, the 20 to 75 or 100 employees, you know, there's never an IT person there. There's always a, you know, whoever's, you know, got the office manager role.

**Michael Sweet** 28:18
Yeah.
Yep.
Yep.

**Rick Snide** 28:36
you know, basically ends up being the person that's doing that. And a lot of them

have somebody that they call, you know, and in some cases they already have a, you know, an MSP also. But yeah, it's a different conversation.

MS **Michael Sweet** 28:52
Yeah.
I have a question for you.
Coming from the record storage business, and this was something I always thought very interesting, I always thought, would it work in another environment? So say, for example, we had Ohio Health as a box customer. They had like 200,000 boxes with us, spending 50 grand a month. Iron Mountain would walk in and say, tell you what,

**Rick Snide** 29:09
Mhm.

MS **Michael Sweet** 29:18
I'll buy your business. You know, because yeah, I mean, these are contracts. And you know, if you leave the contract, you're still on the hook. So we would see that from time to time. And I always was interested, is that something that in like your world would make sense fiscally? Like if you said, hey, here's the deal. I know you work with Microman. You got.

**Rick Snide** 29:20
Mhm.
Mm-hmm.

MS **Michael Sweet** 29:38
six months on the contract, the contracts work worth X, we will buy that out, so to speak, if you do a three-year, you know, agreement with us. Is that something that makes sense from your side of it or?

**Rick Snide** 29:40
Mm-hmm.
Probably not. I mean, the reason being, you know, compared to, you know, maybe fireproof, you know, fireproof has...

**Michael Sweet** 29:53

Okay.

Ohh.

Yep, sure.

**Rick Snide** 30:22

In our case, you know, significant chunk of the cost is salary.

**Michael Sweet** 30:30

Okay. Yep.

**Rick Snide** 30:30

You know, so, you know, we've got relatively expensive technical people that we have to have, you know, available. Now, what we, you know, theoretically could do going down the road is, you know, there's some ways that we could make some of that happen.

**Michael Sweet** 30:36

Sure.

Okay.

**Rick Snide** 30:52

you know, but there's not a lot of, there's not, there's, we don't really even expect to. We'd only expect probability to even make money on the account for the first six months.

**Michael Sweet** 31:07

Okay.

**Rick Snide** 31:08

So, you know, with all the onboarding and, you know, documenting and et cetera, et cetera. So, yeah, it's a dicey business. It's more like...

**Michael Sweet** 31:12
Sure, yep, yep.

**Rick Snide** 31:23
It's more, it's closer to the staffing business, really, when you think about those costs. But then we also have all the tools behind the scenes and all the management of all the people and all, as opposed to staffing, most of the time you're putting a person out there for a rate, right?

**Michael Sweet** 31:29
Okay, yeah.
Sure.
Yep.

**Rick Snide** 31:42
So, yeah, but we do get, we do some creative things here and there, you know, we'll start, you know, you know, an overlap a month maybe sometimes and not charge them for that so they don't have two months of that or, you know, whatever.

**Michael Sweet** 31:43
Yeah.
Sure.
Yep.
Yeah, because that's to me has always been the biggest hurdle with really selling anything. You know, I had the same thing when I tried to sell, you know, capture software. Well, we have a current system and it's under, you know, contracting and or, you know, and I'm always like, gosh, that's such a barrier because it's an easy thing to, you know, it's the first line of, well, can't do business with you because I'm under contract.

**Rick Snide** 32:03
Mmh.
Mhm.

Yeah.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 32:19

Well, what if I could make it so, you know, you're not happy with Microman, so, and here are the reasons why, we are better because of these reasons. And I was just like, gosh, if I could knock that one barrier down, you know, it would, it would, it would help. But, you know, so that's why I was curious, because like I said,

**Rick Snide** 32:25

Mhm.

Mhm.

Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 32:39

in that record storage business, boy, they said they would buy the business if they could see a rate of return within the first, well, they would lose money for 24 months because they basically would say, we'll buy the business, but you guys signed five years with us.

**Rick Snide** 32:54

Five year agreement, yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 32:55

So they say, okay, you know, 20, I think it was 24 months, we'll lose money, but then we'll make it up. And they were okay with, you know, making money those next, you know, 36, which I always question it, but I'm like, okay, if that's my marching orders. Yeah, they have. Yeah. Yeah. And to your point too, though, is once you put a box in the storage, once it's in there,

**Rick Snide** 32:59

Mhm.

Mhm.

Mmh.

They've done the math, right?
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 33:17
If nobody touches it, it doesn't cost you anything other than the rent, you know, for the building. And like Mike James owned two of those buildings, so he...

**Rick Snide** 33:22
Right.

**Michael Sweet** 33:26
That wasn't the issue, so...

**Rick Snide** 33:28
Right, right. Yeah. And in our case, our cost of delivering it goes up every year. So, you know, five years later, you know, we don't we don't really want to be at the same rate, right? We can't charge enough. We can't charge enough to keep up with inflation.

**Michael Sweet** 33:41
Australia.

**Rick Snide** 33:48
salary inflation over five years, you know.

**Michael Sweet** 33:48
Yeah.
Sure, yep.

**Rick Snide** 33:52
To accommodate that, so...
I guess one question to the did BPS just shut down their operations or what?

**Michael Sweet** 34:05
Nope. No, we, when I first started there, we had a one year agreement to kind of see,

you know, feel it out, make sure both parties were still happy with each other. And we were, I just didn't feel like the direction of the digital side was going to, was going to grow at the rate I wanted to and John wanted it to.

**Rick Snide** 34:22
Mhm, mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 34:23
So we pretty much just kind of, you know, said, we'll just part ways. And I think they're still going to try to do it. I don't know. I haven't heard they've hired anybody else or anything. You know, it's a tough, it's really a tough commitment, you know, you know, it's one of those things where if you say you're going to do it, it's a long sales cycle, A.

**Rick Snide** 34:32
Mm-hmm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 34:42
You know, I mean, because again, as we talked about earlier, you're coming in and talking to somebody about changing the way they do business. You know, if they're, say they're 100% paper, well, now everything is going to be digital. Oh my gosh, Betty's been here for 30 years and this is the way she's always done it. You know, so now you get change management thing to work through and

**Rick Snide** 34:50
Mmh.
Mhm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 35:01
So, the time it would take to sell some of these, you know, solutions would be six months, eight months, a year, so...

**Rick Snide** 35:01

Mhm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 35:11
It was just one of those things that we kind of, you know, just did a mutual, you know, gave it a shot. I don't know, I haven't heard from anybody over there if they're going to continue, if they're going to bring another person in. If John's going to say, hey, you know, we tried it, we, you know.

**Rick Snide** 35:15
Yeah.
Mhm.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 35:27
Yeah, we had like, you know, we had one sale, you know, which again, it took that one took eight months. So it's like, it's.

**Rick Snide** 35:34
That was the $8,000 a month one, or was that a different one?

**Michael Sweet** 35:37
No, that was, no, that was a different one. Yeah. So it's just one of those things that, you know, it takes a while. So, and he understood that, you know, he's a really good, good guy, you know, he was, you know, good boss, just kind of, you know, do your thing, bring us, you know, bring us some business. So that's what, so we tried to do.

**Rick Snide** 35:39
Mhm.
Mhm.
Mhm.
Mhm.
Yeah, yeah. And, but that, so that was a project to basically switch them from paper to digital, is what that one project was that you're talking about.

**Michael Sweet** 36:10
Yes, yep.

**Rick Snide** 36:10
Mhm, mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 36:11
Yeah, yeah, you know, it's one of those things that...
I'm surprised it's 2026 and I still talk to people that still have paper. I just, you know, because it's not necessarily, I don't fault them, but you start seeing everybody around you starting to send you everything electronically. You know, so at some point, you know, you think about everybody that uses an accounting

**Rick Snide** 36:21
Mhm.
Mm-hmm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 36:35
You know, some type of accounting system now that's digital, so the amount of paper should overtime be diminishing, but...

**Rick Snide** 36:39
Mmh.
Yeah, right.

**Michael Sweet** 36:45
I still talk to folks and even some bigger companies. They'll be like, oh yeah, we're still doing paper over here in the, you know, manufacturing side. I'm like, what? This does not make sense. But you know, who am I to say? Who am I to say? But I think in the next probably two to three years, because even like

**Rick Snide** 36:48
And.

Mhm.

Yeah, I know.

**Michael Sweet** 37:05

I remember Mike James at Fireproof is like, this won't last forever. We won't have, we won't even have this paper forever. Because a lot of people now are going, I'm keeping my records for seven years. You know, if from a, you know, here's our record retention policy, it's a new one in seven years.

**Rick Snide** 37:09

Mm-hmm.

Mm-hmm.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 37:23

All that stuff has been, we've been, you know, sitting over there fireproof for 30 years, go in and destroy it. There's no reason to, you know, no reason to keep it, you know, because everything now is electronic. I mean, if you think about all the hospitals, you walk into a doctor's office, you're not really filling out anything. Most of them now, it's electronic. You fill it out online before you even go there.

**Rick Snide** 37:29

Yeah.

Yeah.

Yeah.

Right.

Right, right.

**Michael Sweet** 37:44

You know, so when you when you log in, it's electronic, so...

**Rick Snide** 37:47

Right. Yeah. And then they, and then they interact with you electronically too, which is nice, you know.

**Michael Sweet** 37:54
Oh, it's, yeah, there's a lot of advantages to it. Yeah, I'm surprised. I mean, I went and saw my sister over the weekend and my mom for Mother's Day, she's down in Asheville, North Carolina. And my brother-in-law, he's 77, and he still has a flip phone. He's like, I'm not getting a smartphone like,

**Rick Snide** 38:04
Oh yeah.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 38:13
Well, you can't do anything. You can't go to a sporting event, a concert.

**Rick Snide** 38:16
Right, right.

**Michael Sweet** 38:17
You know, I mean, everybody's pushing you to those devices and everything, like you said, everything is electronic. You know, QR codes for everything now. I go to Kroger's trying to buy something. I go, oh, digital special. Save 50 cents. I, you know, take a picture of the QR code and, you know, I'm off to the races. But

**Rick Snide** 38:22
Right.
Yeah.
Right.
Right.

**Michael Sweet** 38:37
Yeah, it's an ever-changing world for sure.

**Rick Snide** 38:42
Sure is. What do you, tell me what you're interested in working on kind of technology-wise yourself.

MS **Michael Sweet** 38:51

Well, you know, as I mentioned earlier about AI, it's kind of, it's fascinating to me. And I really, I've always said, you know, if you don't keep up with it, you're done because everything builds on everything else. You know, so I'm trying to just start to understand the AI piece and kind of where it would fit.

**Rick Snide** 38:57

Mm-hmm.

Mm-hmm.

Mm-hmm.

MS **Michael Sweet** 39:10

in just my life, you know, because it's going to take over. The amount of dollars that are being spent on it, you know, it's going to take over. And it's kind of scary, though, because I'm concerned about just the securities of life.

**Rick Snide** 39:12

Mhm.

Yeah.

Mhm.

MS **Michael Sweet** 39:29

You know, as we talked about, everything is digital, but you get a couple of bad actors figuring out ways to, you know, take your take your information without you knowing it. You know, have a, you know, you start teaching these these AI bots how to do things, they don't they don't know the difference between good and bad.

**Rick Snide** 39:36

Yeah.

Right.

Mhm.

Right, right. Which uh, which tool are you are you messing with?

MS **Michael Sweet** 39:48

Yeah.

None yet. I'm just really looking at, you know, kind of figuring out what I want to play around with and, you know.

**Rick Snide** 39:59

Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 40:01

How about yourself? Have you?

Worked on some.

Yep.

Yep.

Copilot, yeah.

**Rick Snide** 40:22

Which is.

So I have that too. I have ChatGPT, I have Copilot. Copilot's nice because it's in, if you've got the pay version of it, it's embedded in your Outlook and Microsoft Teams and all that. So, you know, I can say.

Um...

What was that conversation I had with Michael Sweet? And actually it could go into this transcript and find this transcript for me, right? And so that's nice, but I've recently, I've been spending more time with Claude, which is anthropic, right?

**Michael Sweet** 40:53

Oh, perfect, yeah.

Sure.

Yep, I've heard a lot about that, yeah.

**Rick Snide** 41:06

Ohh.

It is, I would recommend that as a, I think it's pretty user-friendly. We're doing some things with it that aren't user-friendly, but we're in the process of replacing, and we're not replacing the person, but

**Michael Sweet** 41:12
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 41:30
replacing the work of, you know, one of the people on our account management team really spends his entire day just chasing down reports and, you know, things like this for various meetings and getting all that stuff together. We're...

**Michael Sweet** 41:39
Ugh.

**Rick Snide** 41:48
You know, spending like...
maybe not even a week, a week in calendar, probably 2 weeks on the calendar, but probably more like 20 hours total, would replace half of this guy's job with automation. And what we want to do is put him over in a different role. He's a great guy. We don't want to lose him.

**Michael Sweet** 42:08
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 42:10
So we're, but we're automating a bunch of what he's doing. You know, I'm personally automating a lot of what I'm doing. You know, I've got, you know, I personally am the director also of this division of the MSP division.
The, and I've got a pretty thick slide deck that I put together for the team every month of all of our performance for last month and, you know, month over month and all this other stuff. I have it pull all that stuff, put together all the PowerPoint slides.

**Michael Sweet** 42:48
Oh, nice.

**Rick Snide** 42:49
you know, all the everything, you know, and it's just, you know, a one-shot.

**Michael Sweet** 42:51
Yeah.

**Rick Snide** 42:56
A one-shot thing, you know, whereas it would take me.

**Michael Sweet** 42:57
Yep.

**Rick Snide** 43:01
Probably 4 hours.

**Michael Sweet** 43:04
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 43:04
you know, to do that. There's some value in me doing it because I have to look at the numbers and, you know, and the numbers become more ingrained in me, I suppose, right? But I can look at the numbers after it puts all the numbers together too, right?

**Michael Sweet** 43:16
Sure, right.
Right. Absolutely. Well, and you know, that's the, I think that's the direction that a lot of businesses need to be going with this, this type of AI is just starting very slowly and saying, okay, what are we doing? You know, to your point, I got account managers burning how many hours a week?

**Rick Snide** 43:30
Mm-mm.
Mhm.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 43:41

There really doesn't have to be, you know, or AI if, because if all the data's there, if it's just, if it's on your network, that's the beauty of AI. You know, now it can take all that information, because that's been the, you know, the problem with everything forever. You know, where's that email that I sent out last week to Rick? I don't know where it's at, you know, you spend 20 minutes looking for it.

**Rick Snide** 43:42

Yeah.

Mhm.

Yeah.

Yeah.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 44:02

Where if now you can just basically say, you know, give me all the correspondence for Rick Snide for the last two weeks, instantly, it's there. I mean, so.

**Rick Snide** 44:08

Yeah.

Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 44:11

Yeah, that's the types of things I think businesses can really look at and say, how can we save time? Like my wife, she spent so much time at the bar association doing, she's the director of special events and member engagement. But her boss is like, hey, how many attorneys were, you know,
graduated from Capital Law, blah, blah, blah. It's in the system, but there's not an easy way to get it because they have an antiquated system. So she's spending too much time where she had an AI, you know, agent that could do that for her. And they just bought a new package that has that capabilities. So it'll make her life a lot easier.

**Rick Snide** 44:32

Mhm.

Right, right.

Mhm.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 44:52

And she can do what she needs to be doing, not waste, not wasting time, but...

**Rick Snide** 44:52

Mhm.

Yeah, it's not very valuable time.

**Michael Sweet** 44:58

No, it's not, you know, she needs to be engaged with the members. That's her, you know, that's her focus. And that's the most important thing to me is customer, you know, service. I mean, as I get older, I'm like, gosh, what happened? I always go back to the good old days when, you know, people cared about businesses and you, you know, when we were at Fireproof at Christmas, we used to.

**Rick Snide** 45:01

Yeah, yeah, yeah.

Yeah.

Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 45:17

take cookies to our best customers and, you know, just those little things that say, hey, we do remember you, you know, and you, we, you know, you matter to us. That's all that people want to hear, you know? But it's hard because people, I don't know, I think the younger generation are

**Rick Snide** 45:20

Mhm.

Yeah.

Yeah.

Yeah, yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 45:37
They're missing that because of the phone, the...

**Rick Snide** 45:41
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 45:42
Text and chat, you know, the, that's the part that really kind of, you know, in my opinion, you kind of need to, there was that years ago, there was a commercial about...

**Rick Snide** 45:43
Yeah, I agree, I agree.

**Michael Sweet** 45:54
I remember who it was. They basically just start passed out airline tickets and said, hey, we need to get in front of our customers again.

**Rick Snide** 46:01
I remember that ad. I remember that ad. Yeah, it was the CEO or whatever is in the, you know, the big meeting room and he starts passing out plain text and he says our best customer just fired us.

**Michael Sweet** 46:02
Remember that one, but...
What's American?
Yep.

**Rick Snide** 46:14
And uh, we gotta we gotta get back to, you know, basically get back to what what what we should be doing, which is being in front of the customers.

**Michael Sweet** 46:23

Yeah, well, you know, it's so easy to keep them. It's so hard to find new ones, you know, but I think that gets lost on, you know.

**Rick Snide** 46:29

Mhm.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 46:32

Like at VRC, they had a total different attic. They didn't care.

**Rick Snide** 46:36

Mm-hmm.

**Michael Sweet** 46:36

Yeah, if they leave, they leave. What? That is, oh my god.

**Rick Snide** 46:39

Right, costs so much to acquire a new customer.

**Michael Sweet** 46:42

Oh, it's so many hours. Yeah. And the ones you have, man, just talk. I always tell, hold on to them tight, you know, because, you know, and it really boils down to just communication. You know, if you have, you know, I used to do like a monthly, you know, not a quarterly business review, but like a monthly review, just 10 minutes.

**Rick Snide** 46:44

Yeah, yeah.

Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 47:01

I just want to see how you're doing. Is everything working the way it should be, the way I promised it was going to work? If not, okay, well, let's figure out, because a lot of people, they just quietly leave you. You'll get a notice saying, yep, we're not going to renew our contract. You're like, what? I thought we were... And some people will tell you.

**Rick Snide** 47:02

Mm-hmm.

Mhm.

Mhm.

Yeah, right.

Yeah, right.

**Michael Sweet** 47:21

but a lot don't. They just, and then you kind of scratch your head going, cow, we just lost another, how did we lose this $20,000 a year account? What happened?

**Rick Snide** 47:22

Right, right.

Yeah, yeah, yeah, right, right. You know, one of the things I was wondering, I don't know if you've thought about this at this point, and maybe it's too early to think about this, but you know, kind of based on you know, knowing what our business is, do you have

you know, off the top of your head, three, 4, 5 customers that you say, you know, these would be good people that I should go talk to.

**Michael Sweet** 47:59

I definitely think Red Roof would be, you know, I know we did that one thing with BPS, but they're not going to, they're not going to go after that, you know, and the guy that I worked with, he definitely is, you know, we've been friends. I mean, we started out as just a business relationship. He's got season tickets to the Blue Jackets. I do. We get together every every game, you know, and

**Rick Snide** 48:06

Mhm.

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 48:19

commiserate about how bad they're doing her. But yeah, I think I could probably think of two or three that, you know, definitely could, you know, hopefully make a dent right away.

**Rick Snide** 48:19
Mm-hmm.
Yeah.
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 48:31
You know, it's kind of hard to think about right now, but I mean, I can just start, you know, I'll start just calling people and asking around, hey, how you doing? You know, and because again, I can, you know, the people I, the relationships I have, I've had for years. So it's not like an intrusive, hey, I'm trying to sell you something. Hey, Rick, guess what?

**Rick Snide** 48:39
Mhm.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 48:51
I need to tell you something. It's not that. It's just, hey, how you been? And by the way, you know, are you happy with your current provider? Oh, we don't have one. Oh, OK. Thanks.

**Rick Snide** 48:51
Right, right, right.
Right.
Right.
Right, right, right, right.

**Michael Sweet** 49:01
So.

**Rick Snide** 49:04
Yeah.

The was gonna ask you something else along those lines.
Well, anyway.
I wanted to, we got about 15 minutes left. I wanted it to really kind of...

**Michael Sweet** 49:20
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 49:26
hand you the remainder of the time and let you ask some questions. Make sure that...
Oh, you know, one of the things I was going to ask before you do that was, what kind of tools are you using for sales? What are you comfortable with at this point?

**Michael Sweet** 49:44
So I've had BPS with Salesforce.

**Rick Snide** 49:48
Okay.

**Michael Sweet** 49:50
At VRC, we had kind of a homegrown system.
Trying to think what else I've used. They're all pretty similar, so you know what I mean? It's kind of like, you know, if you've used Salesforce, everything else kind of is similar format, and you know, so...

**Rick Snide** 50:01
Mhm, Yeah.
Yeah.
Yeah, yeah, they all kind of do the same thing.

**Michael Sweet** 50:12
They do, yeah, you know, um, and that was gonna be one of my questions is kind of, you know, what's the layout or, you know, from a...

**Rick Snide** 50:18
Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 50:19

Just from a structural standpoint of, do you have a CRM system and then, you know, kind of...

**Rick Snide** 50:26

Mhm.

**Michael Sweet** 50:28

How does that work?

**Rick Snide** 50:29

Right, right. Yeah, I can jump into that. So we were, as I mentioned, a Salesforce partner and had a Salesforce consulting business. We just left Salesforce, although we still have a couple of licenses so that we can access some of our old stuff.

**Michael Sweet** 50:33

Okay.
Yep.

**Rick Snide** 50:51

It was so expensive, and you know, after we sold the Salesforce group, it just didn't really make sense to try to keep maintaining Salesforce.

**Michael Sweet** 51:02

Yeah.

**Rick Snide** 51:07

So we switched to a package that you, well, two packages that you probably, one you know for sure, which is HubSpot. And then the other one you don't know of is called Halo. And so Halo is our ERP system, if you want to think about it that way. That's our backend.

**Michael Sweet** 51:16

Yep.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 51:28
ticketing system. So we used to have absolutely everything on Salesforce. I mean, from our phone system, you know, through our financials, through everything. And so we've pulled out of all of that. We've got a lot of it in this Halo system. So our chat.

**Michael Sweet** 51:28
Okay.
Okay.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 51:46
is in the Halo system, our ticketing is in the Halo system. I would say all of inside sales is in the Halo system, so the project team and the account managers are putting opportunities in there. I would say that we're just implementing HubSpot because
Our marketing system was also Salesforce. It was Salesforce bought a company a while back called Pardot, and it was, we had that. So we've moved off of that to HubSpot, but we just did that. So all of...

**Michael Sweet** 52:09
Sure.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 52:26
outside sales, you know, prospecting and probably the, you know, the sales funnel, you know, all the way until it becomes a real opportunity, maybe will be in HubSpot.

**Michael Sweet** 52:39
Mhm.
Okay. Yeah, we actually, I tried to get John over at BPS to get into HubSpot because I reached out to a guy and, you know, he was down in Dallas and I was, you know, saw

the product. I'm like, oh my gosh, this is pretty, it's pretty nice because they didn't really have a system.

**Rick Snide** 52:43

So.

Yeah.

Yeah, yeah, yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 53:00

They had one of their own, you know, I mean, they had Salesforce, but they didn't really use it that well. And they were kind of looking for alternatives, like, you know, found HubSpot. I'm like, hey, I think it's cheaper, obviously. So that'd be nice to use that because I sat in a couple of demos and kind of showed the power of the product. I'm like, wow.

**Rick Snide** 53:06

Mhm.

Yeah.

Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 53:19

And you know, marketing stuff, yeah.

**Rick Snide** 53:19

It's a sweet product. It's a sweet product. And I think we'll have it probably, like I said, when the opportunities get to, you know, a stage where, you know, they're close to closing, I think we will

**Michael Sweet** 53:36

Mhm.

**Rick Snide** 53:38

probably push those into Halo so that all of the opportunities that at that point are in Halo. Because Halo, you know, then we've got a natural process for how that becomes a, you know, a proposal or a statement of work and an invoice and all that other stuff is, you know, goes that direction. So.

MS **Michael Sweet** 53:59
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 54:01
But maybe, maybe not. You know, I think it might be just as easy. I mean, it's not like we're, you know, closing 100 deals a week, right? So, you know, it might be just as easy to manage all of the outside sales, you know, all the way to close in HubSpot and then say,

MS **Michael Sweet** 54:11
Right.

**Rick Snide** 54:21
OK, we got a winner, you know, and and then put it in as a new customer in the in the Halo system, right?

MS **Michael Sweet** 54:24
Right.
Yep.
So.

**Rick Snide** 54:32
So...

MS **Michael Sweet** 54:34
What about the technical side?
Walk me kind of through, do you guys, do you have like a pre-sales person or?
Wholesales people are.

**Rick Snide** 54:45
Yeah, so we don't have a pre-sales person. We've tried that a couple of times over the years. In fact, I think when we spoke last is when we were looking for an inside

sales person. And I think that's not what you were looking for, you know, at that time. But we've tried that back and forth over the years.

MS **Michael Sweet** 54:48

Okay.

Okay.

Right.

**Rick Snide** 55:08

I think, you know, I've come to the conclusion over the last couple years that... you know, it needs a different kind of prospecting. You know, I mean, we still need to do, we still do need some ******** prospecting, you know, like through LinkedIn, like you said, and some stuff like that. But the just smiling and dialing model of inside sales, I think is, you know, those days may be gone.

MS **Michael Sweet** 55:19

Yeah.

I would agree. Yeah. Yep.

**Rick Snide** 55:36

Yeah, so we don't have, we don't have a pre-sales, you know, model. We're trying, we'll be rebooting our website here, removing ERP and really trying to re-engineer it for AI searches so that we come up, so when we...

MS **Michael Sweet** 55:52

Okay.

**Rick Snide** 55:54

Because right now, everybody's having a problem with their website appearing in searches, right? Because AI searches for stuff differently than Google searches for stuff. And so, you know, getting yourself to appear in a search result now is different than it was with Google.

MS **Michael Sweet** 56:07

Right.
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 56:14
So we need to re-engineer our website to accommodate that.
But.
So then after the sale, then the way that what we normally do is we have a handoff from sales to account management, and then sales stays involved. Sales goes to the onboarding meeting along with account management, along with

**Michael Sweet** 56:35
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 56:45
the onboarding team and then basically you'd hand it over to those people, you know. Well, let me back up. The mechanics are...

**Michael Sweet** 56:54
Yep.

**Rick Snide** 56:58
You know, you have a handoff meeting with our team, right, on the inside team and say, here's all the little intricacies you need to know about this place. You know, Sue is actually the sister of so-and-so, and she's the office manager.

**Michael Sweet** 57:08
Right.
Right.

**Rick Snide** 57:17
So, we need to treat her, you know, with kid gloves, and you know, they've got this other thing they're really unhappy about, and did it, did it right, and just kind of share and document that, you know, that institutional knowledge, if you will. So, we do that first, and then we have the onboarding meeting with the customer, and you pretty much introduce people, and they get rolling with gathering data, and...

**Michael Sweet** 57:30
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 57:39
introductions and all that kind of stuff around the company. And then, you know, it takes us, depending on the size of the company, takes us a couple of, well, by the end of the day, we're able to support them. Like all their people can call in, all their machines, or most of their machines, we should be able to.
connect to like when they have a problem and like get on their machine with them, all the back end systems, all that stuff too. So we try to achieve that on day one, but then there's a lot of little extra like that that happens over the next couple weeks. We have sales.

**Michael Sweet** 58:02
Okay.
Sure, OK.

**Rick Snide** 58:20
check in between the account manager and sales, we check in basically every day for the first week.

**Michael Sweet** 58:32
K.

**Rick Snide** 58:32
And then weekly for the from there on, and then you know, and then we'll have a regular monthly cadence. We, I we like sales to check in like at the 90 day mark again, and to say how it's going, and I think that's just good, you know, good relationship management.

**Michael Sweet** 58:45
Okay.
Sure.
Oh, absolutely, yeah.

**Rick Snide** 58:53
So we do that and really account management then and our projects team handle that virtual CIO function, technical manager function. So the account management role does the account management meetings every month and keeps on track of projects and

**Michael Sweet** 59:05
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 59:15
problems and things like that, right? The project management team does projects and they do that virtual CIO or technical manager role, and the account manager will pull them in for discussions with the customer. If they need to, we need to talk about moving them all to the cloud. They've got, you know, 4 servers on site. We need to get them moved to the cloud.

**Michael Sweet** 59:30
Gotcha.

**Rick Snide** 59:38
and you know, et cetera, et cetera, et cetera. So they'll do that. But so the account manager doesn't have a quota, but they do, they're responsible for all of the installed account sales, if you will, which is basically pulling in the project team to do.

**Michael Sweet** 59:53
Gotcha. Okay.

**Rick Snide** 59:58
Like I said, a cloud migration or new firewalls or, you know, whatever.
And then so the outside sales role, we just keep focused on how do we keep landing new deals, right? Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 1:00:14
Sure. Yep. Okay.

Do, um, how many sales people do you have as far as outside sales, not the account managers?
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 1:00:30
We've got, depending on how you want to count it, we've got three people that are in the account management role. And then we have one person who's a procurement manager who handles, you know, customers need, you know, 12 laptops or, you know, we need to order firewall. We manage all the renewals for. Warranties, all that stuff, right? We have someone doing that, and then on the projects team, there's two main people that will do the technical manager role, the VCIO role, and then there's two other people that can, you know, participate in that too, but this...

**Michael Sweet** 1:00:53
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 1:01:11
basically the two of them that are doing that, that really, it's a, usually what we're doing is pulling them in annually to assess where they are and where they need to go and what their security posture is, what we need to be.

**Michael Sweet** 1:01:15
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 1:01:32
You know, planning to change, you know, security-wise with them to keep them safe and growing, you know, safer.

**Michael Sweet** 1:01:39
Sure. Right. Now, do we have, like if somebody has an issue with the 800 number, calls in and we have somebody live answering the call and...

**Rick Snide** 1:01:41
Yeah.

Right, so there's, um, I think there's...
12 people on the phones of different levels. Basically, the eight of them are answering phones and emails and chats all the time. And then it gets escalated up to others like

**Michael Sweet** 1:02:00
Okay.
Okay.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 1:02:15
for level 2 and level 3 people. And then really the project team people can be level 4, if you want to think about it that way. And then we do cover, our normal hours are 7 to 5 or 7 to 6.

**Michael Sweet** 1:02:18
Gotcha.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 1:02:35
And then we have someone that's on call that works from 3 to 11. And then it's just a call back from 11 to 7 in the morning. So we do have 24-hour coverage. It's just, you know, a little bit less, you know.

**Michael Sweet** 1:02:47
Okay, yeah.
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 1:02:54
numbers of people.

**Michael Sweet** 1:02:54
Yep, sure. Now, is it pretty much Ohio? Do you have customers outside of Ohio or just mainly central and...

**Rick Snide** 1:03:03
It's mainly central Ohio. We have some that aren't, and that is because they've got a branch somewhere. Typically they're based here. We've got it, we do have a couple that don't have a branch here like that, but are, you know, like we've got.

**Michael Sweet** 1:03:05
Okay.
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 1:03:20
One that comes to mind is in Washington, DC. You know, somebody here, you know, some IT director here moved to Washington, DC and took over, no, he was an IT director, he was the association director, moved to Washington, DC, took over a nonprofit there and he's...
ask us if we could be their IT company out there. So we're like, yeah, sure, we can do that. So, but we do focus on central Ohio just because there's enough business here. And we'd like to be able, if we have to, to drive out to do support. Otherwise, we have to round somebody up. Like in DC, we've got a person that we call in DC that goes out there if we need

**Michael Sweet** 1:03:43
Oh, nice.
Nice.
Okay.
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 1:04:05
Boots on the street.

**Michael Sweet** 1:04:05
Oh, good.
Sure. Okay. Cool.

**Rick Snide** 1:04:08
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 1:04:10
Well, I guess the last question, next steps.

**Rick Snide** 1:04:14
Next steps would be, you are the very first person I've talked to from starting this process.

**Michael Sweet** 1:04:22
Ohh, first one in is always the best.

**Rick Snide** 1:04:27
Set the bar, right?

**Michael Sweet** 1:04:28
I have, yes. Yep. You'll be comparing everybody else to me like, well, that person's okay, but man, something about sweet I like, so.

**Rick Snide** 1:04:29
Right, good.
Yeah.
Next, what I would do is have you meet with Cindy, who is our marketing director.
And I don't know if you met with her before. She, yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 1:04:42
Okay.
Okay.
I did actually, yep.
Yeah.

**Rick Snide** 1:04:52

So I would, I'll connect you with her and we'll, you know, we'll go that route and she's she would.

**Michael Sweet** 1:05:00
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 1:05:04
She would probably, or not probably, she would be your manager, but I will also, you know, I'm very much integral in the sales process, so it's not like, you know, the main reason to have her involved is because of...

**Michael Sweet** 1:05:10
Okay.
Sure.

**Rick Snide** 1:05:24
you know, keeping the systems going and, you know, I think it's good to be working closely with marketing anyway. And, you know, this way you wouldn't be dependent on me all the time for all of it, you know, so.

**Michael Sweet** 1:05:28
Yep.
Oh, absolutely. Yeah.
Sure.
Okay.

**Rick Snide** 1:05:42
I'll do that. I'll let her know and I will.
I'll just have her. I've got your email, I think. Yeah, it's on your resume, I think.

**Michael Sweet** 1:05:55
Yep, D. Sweetness 28.

**Rick Snide** 1:05:56
Um...

Yeah.
I will send that to her and just ask her to get connected with you and figure out a good time to meet.

MS **Michael Sweet** 1:06:08
Okay.
Fantastic.

**Rick Snide** 1:06:12
Well, it was good speaking with you, Michele.

MS **Michael Sweet** 1:06:13
And then, yeah, it was good catching up. Yeah, when it was funny because, but when the when I talked to the recruiter, he's like, yeah, this is, you know, company in Westerville and he said the name of it. I'm like, oh my gosh, that that that throws me back to 20, whatever, 14. I remember going to your office and meeting with you guys and

**Rick Snide** 1:06:25
Yeah.
Right, right.

MS **Michael Sweet** 1:06:33
Because I think Jeremy might have actually been working there at that time.

**Rick Snide** 1:06:36
He might have been, I feel like, I feel like he actually recommended you.

MS **Michael Sweet** 1:06:43
Yep, because he was there for two or three. I just looked him up the other day, so I was like, I know he worked at Revolution. Let me figure it out. Yeah, so.

**Rick Snide** 1:06:52
Yeah.
Yeah, he was with us for a few years.

And then Keith Carter, I think, was after him. And Keith was with us for, I think, seven years. So, yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 1:07:04
Oh wow, okay.
Yeah, Jeremy's, gosh, he's done really well from selfies at Worldwide Technologies.

**Rick Snide** 1:07:06
And...
I don't know where he is. My wife follows him on Facebook and sees him with his kids and all.

**Michael Sweet** 1:07:12
He's like it.
Oh my God, yeah, he's always going here and going there. And yeah, he's, I think he's an area vice president now. He's done, he's done well for himself. So, and yeah, he's a great guy. I mean, we had so much fun working together at Cornell. I mean, he was really young too. Just, he was probably in his 20s back then.

**Rick Snide** 1:07:21
Yeah, yeah.
He's a good guy.
Yeah.
Yeah.

**Michael Sweet** 1:07:38
Gosh, we go down there and he's like a kid in a candy store.
It just, you know, getting on a plane and going down to, you know, going to Dallas, and it was it was a good time. So, well, I do appreciate your time today. This is fun catching up, and yep, look forward to hearing from Cindy and...

**Rick Snide** 1:07:49
Yeah.
Yep, same.

**Michael Sweet** 1:07:57
Hopefully be part of your team someday.

**Rick Snide** 1:07:59
Yeah, well, it was good talking with you, Michael, and I'll pass you on to Cindy here and we'll keep moving.

**Michael Sweet** 1:08:01
All right.
Okay, sounds good. Thanks. Bye bye.

**Rick Snide** 1:08:06
Alright, thanks. See you.

**Rick Snide** stopped transcription